



A PACKED FLIGHT DECK

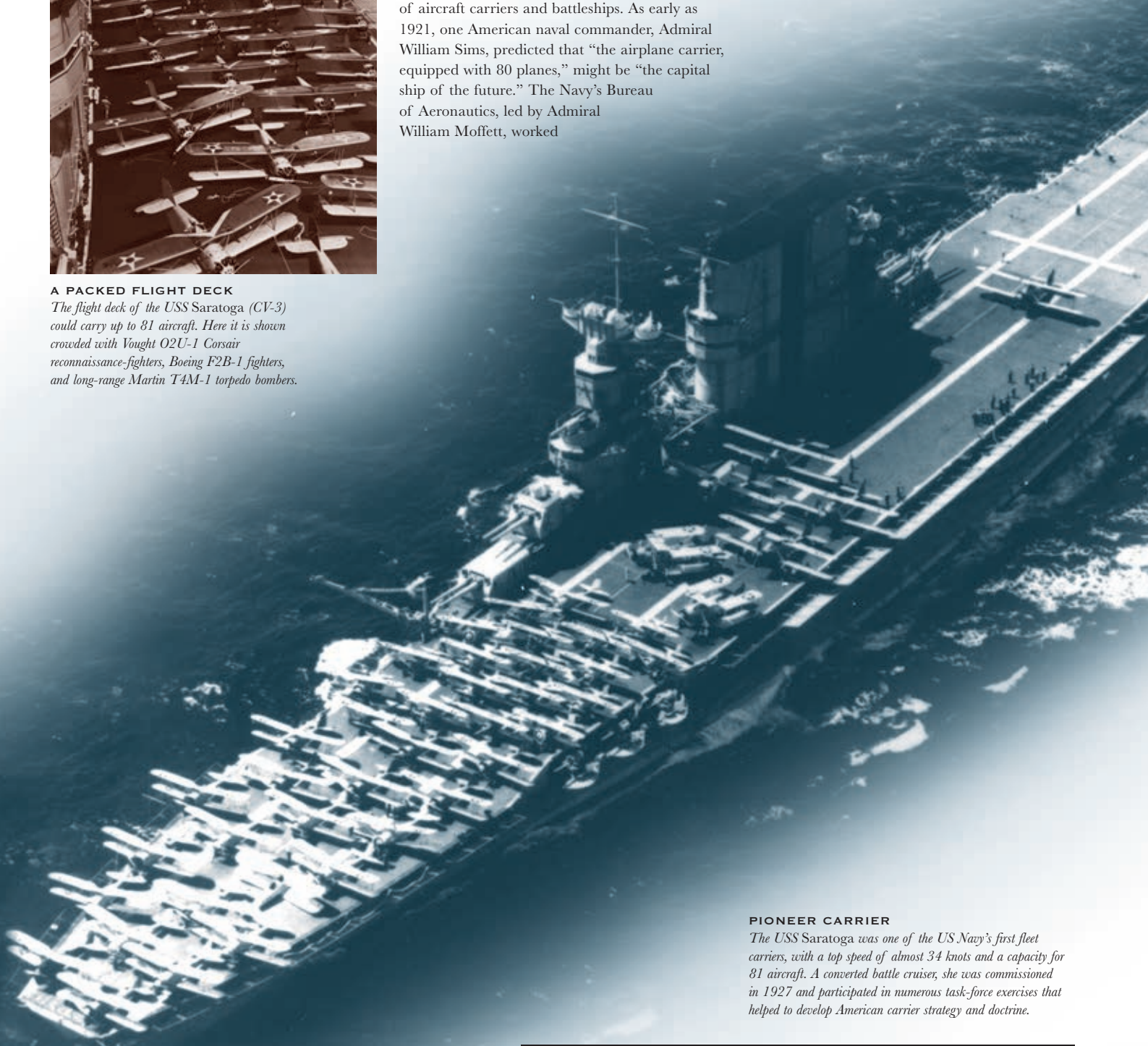
The flight deck of the USS Saratoga (CV-3) could carry up to 81 aircraft. Here it is shown crowded with Vought O2U-1 Corsair reconnaissance-fighters, Boeing F2B-1 fighters, and long-range Martin T4M-1 torpedo bombers.

and funnel. But until 1937 the aerial element of the Fleet Air Arm was under the direct control of the RAF and consistently starved of funds and first-rate aircraft by air commanders for whom naval aviation was a peripheral concern.

In the United States, the pivotal debate was not about the virtues of independent air power as opposed to an air force under naval command, but rather about the relative importance and roles of aircraft carriers and battleships. As early as 1921, one American naval commander, Admiral William Sims, predicted that “the airplane carrier, equipped with 80 planes,” might be “the capital ship of the future.” The Navy’s Bureau of Aeronautics, led by Admiral William Moffett, worked

vigorously to establish the importance of naval aviation. But less air-minded admirals, although aware of the usefulness of aircraft, believed they should be employed in support of battleships, in a reconnaissance or air-defense role, and tended to dismiss the idea of using seaborne aircraft as a prime attack force.

The first US aircraft carrier, USS *Langley*, entered



PIONEER CARRIER

The USS Saratoga was one of the US Navy’s first fleet carriers, with a top speed of almost 34 knots and a capacity for 81 aircraft. A converted battle cruiser, she was commissioned in 1927 and participated in numerous task-force exercises that helped to develop American carrier strategy and doctrine.